UNIT 2 · CHAPTER 6 · HOUSE & DIVIDED

Bleeding Kansas

How one law tore open the question everyone had tried to bury — and turned politics into violence. 1854–1860.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

How one law tore open the question everyone had tried to bury — and turned politics into violence. 1854–1860.

How does a country that kept finding compromises finally run out of them?

A Line on the Map

THE DEAL THAT HELD

For a generation, Congress had kept the Union together with lines and bargains. The Missouri Compromise of 1820 drew a line across the map — slavery allowed below it, banned above — and the Compromise of 1850 patched the peace again.

Each deal bought time. None answered the real question: would the new western lands be free or slave? By the 1850s, the country was running out of room to keep dodging it.

John Brown — daguerreotype, c. 1846–47, public domain (National Portrait Gallery).

The Kansas–Nebraska Act

1854

Senator Stephen Douglas of Illinois wanted a railroad to the Pacific and Southern votes to get it. His price was a law that let the settlers of Kansas and Nebraska vote slavery up or down for themselves — an idea called popular sovereignty.

To do it, the law erased the Missouri Compromise line. Land that had been promised free could now become slave by a show of hands. The North was stunned, and a new Republican Party rose almost overnight to stop slavery's spread.

"Southern Chivalry — Argument versus Club's" — lithograph by John L. Magee, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).

A House Already Dividing

THE MAP IN 1854

Free states, slave states — and the territories the Act threw open to a vote.

The United States in 1854. Kansas and Nebraska (gold) were the territories the Kansas–Nebraska Act opened to popular sovereignty, erasing the old 36°30′ line. · Map © ShadowDog Digital Studios

A Race for Kansas

THE RUSH

If slavery in Kansas came down to a vote, then whoever got the most voters there would win. Both sides poured people in. Pro-slavery “border ruffians” crossed from Missouri to vote illegally and stuff ballot boxes; Northern aid societies shipped in free-soil settlers — and rifles.

Soon Kansas had two rival governments — a pro-slavery one at Lecompton and a free-state one at Topeka — each calling the other a fraud. One territory could not hold two futures.

Dred Scott — photograph, c. 1857, public domain (Library of Congress / Missouri Historical Society).

Bleeding Kansas

1855–1859

The arguments turned to bloodshed. A pro-slavery mob sacked the town of Lawrence; in revenge, the abolitionist John Brown and his sons killed five pro-slavery settlers at Pottawatomie Creek. Raids and reprisals followed.

Newspapers gave the territory a grim nickname that stuck: “Bleeding Kansas.” For the first time, Americans were killing each other in large numbers over slavery.

Abraham Lincoln — photograph, 1858, public domain (Library of Congress).

Violence Reaches the Senate

1856

The fever reached Washington itself. After Senator Charles Sumner of Massachusetts gave a blistering speech against slavery and insulted a Southern senator, Congressman Preston Brooks of South Carolina walked onto the Senate floor and beat him with a cane until it broke.

Sumner needed years to recover. The North was horrified; much of the South cheered and mailed Brooks new canes. Even the Senate was no longer a safe place to argue.

1860 campaign cartoon — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

Dred Scott

1857

Then the Supreme Court tried to end the fight by law. In the case of Dred Scott, an enslaved man who sued for his freedom, the Court ruled that Black Americans could not be citizens — and that Congress had no power to ban slavery in any territory.

Meant to settle everything, it settled nothing. It enraged the North, gutted popular sovereignty, and made it look as if the whole federal government now belonged to slavery's defenders.

“The Union Is Dissolved!” — broadside, Charleston Mercury, December 20, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

SPRINGFIELD, ILLINOIS · 1858

A house divided against itself cannot stand. I believe this government cannot endure, permanently half slave and half free.

Seven Illinois Towns

1858

That year a tall, little-known Springfield lawyer named Abraham Lincoln challenged Douglas for his Senate seat. Across seven Illinois towns, the two men debated slavery for hours before huge crowds — the famous Lincoln–Douglas debates.

Douglas kept the Senate seat. But Lincoln's steady moral case — that slavery was a wrong that must not be allowed to spread — carried in the newspapers and made him a national figure.

John Brown — daguerreotype, c. 1846–47, public domain (National Portrait Gallery).

Harpers Ferry

1859

John Brown came back. In October 1859 he led a small band in a raid on the federal arsenal at Harpers Ferry, Virginia, hoping to seize weapons and spark a mass uprising of the enslaved.

The raid failed within days, and Brown was captured and hanged. But his death split the country in two: much of the North mourned a martyr, while the South saw final proof that its neighbors meant to destroy it by force.

"Southern Chivalry — Argument versus Club's" — lithograph by John L. Magee, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Four-Way Race

NOVEMBER 1860

The Democratic Party split North and South, and the election of 1860 became a four-way race. Abraham Lincoln won with about 40% of the popular vote and not a single Southern state — yet he swept the free states and won the electoral college.

For the first time, a party opposed to slavery's spread held the White House. The South read the result as a declaration of war on its way of life.

Dred Scott — photograph, c. 1857, public domain (Library of Congress / Missouri Historical Society).

The Union Comes Apart

WINTER 1860–61

Lincoln would not take office until March, but the South did not wait. On December 20, 1860, South Carolina voted to leave the Union, and six more Deep South states followed within weeks.

In February they joined to form the Confederate States of America. A generation of compromises was over. The only question left was whether the country would come apart in peace or in blood — and the answer was waiting at a fort in Charleston Harbor.

Abraham Lincoln — photograph, 1858, public domain (Library of Congress).

Seven Flashpoints

YOUR TURN

Chapter 6 is really seven short fuses, each burning toward war. Step into any one as a historian — read the sources, weigh the sides, and decide for yourself.